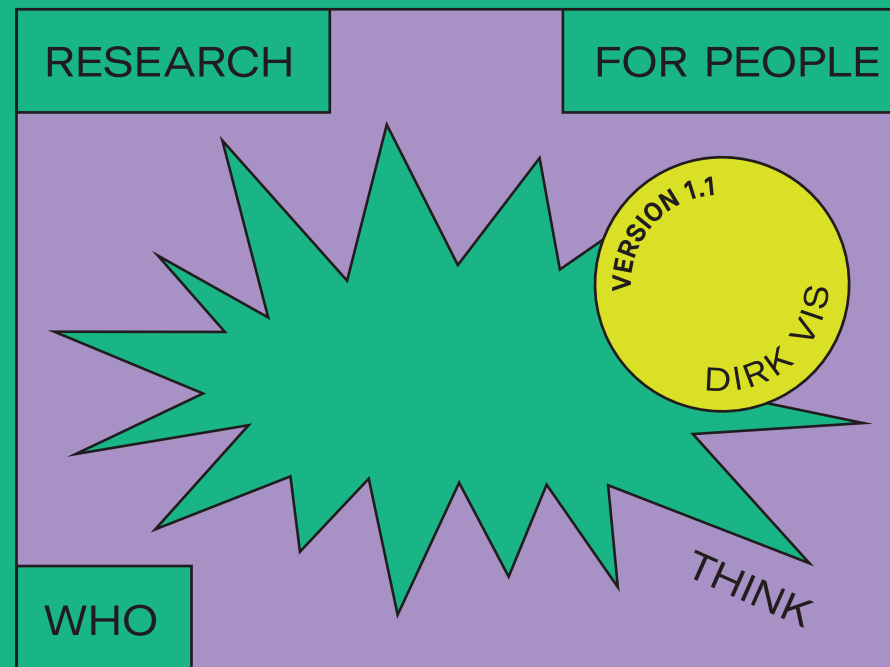


What • is • artistic • research? What is a research document? How do these relate to the making process, invention, and creativity? What exactly is expected of me? If you have ever asked yourself any of these questions, then this book is for you. We will be addressing here all relevant aspects of the research and documentation process, such as: finding the right topic and approach; formulating your research question; working out your methods; choosing one or more suitable writing styles; and considering the possible roles of visual, virtual, auditory, embodied, and spatial materials. ¶

RESEARCH FOR PEOPLE WHO (THINK THEY) WOULD RATHER CREATE

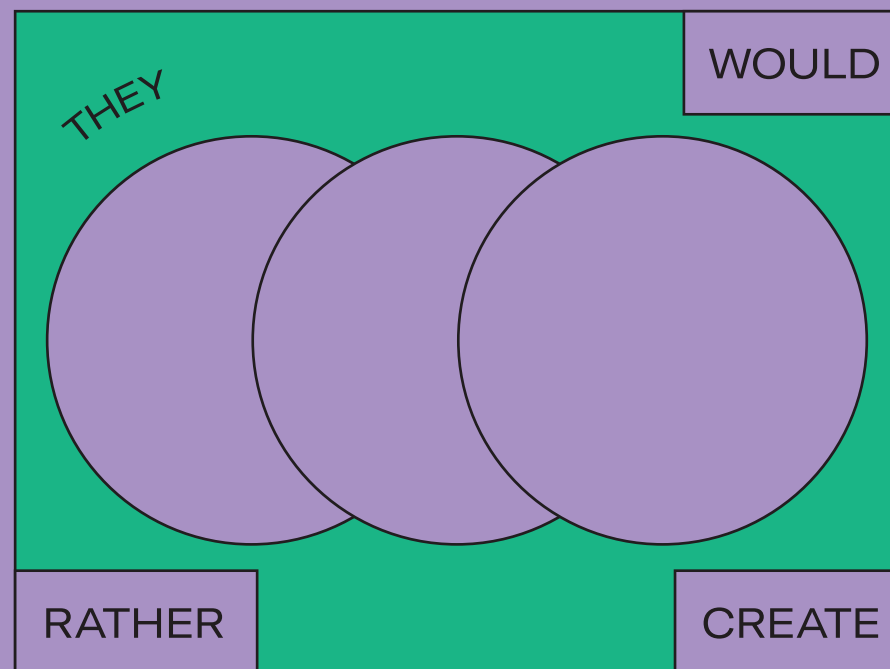


At • the • heart • of this book are dozens of examples from the field of art and design – each of which illustrates one specific aspect of developing a thesis, essay, paper, report, proposal, research document, or however else it may be referred to in your own setting. You can read this book from cover to cover, or you can immediately flip to those subjects which you find most relevant at any given moment. Ultimately, this book is an invitation to contribute – quite literally, with your own projects, examples, and questions – since our goal is to help you develop your own research. #



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► See: *Finding a Research Question*, p. 24

You may be fixated on a certain broad topic, feeling that by focusing on something more limited, you would be untrue to your original motivations. This kind of attitude is unhelpful: sticking to a topic that is too broad costs a lot of time and leads to confusion. Preliminary research will allow you to narrow down the scope of your further research. [1] Ironically, by addressing a specific topic (“the role of the authoritative voiceover in Dutch *Tegenlicht* TV documentaries”) you will automatically address the broader topic (“non-fiction visual storytelling”) that you are interested in, in a way that is relevant and fruitful instead of shaky and uninformed. Furthermore, studying actual art or design practices and examples instead of general ideas (“illustrations in sex education in the Netherlands from 1890 until 1980” instead of “love”) can lead to meaningful conclusions. [2] In your research question, refrain from using generic words such as art, design, communication, etc. Instead, ask yourself what is the smallest, concrete practice or object that triggered your curiosity. Keep this tiny element (a certain sign, sound, action, etc.) in the back of your mind at all times to check whether your newest ventures are still relevant to this initial spark of curiosity.

In some cases, approaching a topic head-on can be so difficult that an all-encompassing encyclopaedic perspective is in fact the most suitable. Another useful approach can be to write short topic-based paragraphs, rather than long chapters. In practice, however, these approaches usually end up costing even more effort, because you will now have to design a suitable, overarching editorial approach to somehow connect all these different fragments. In the 18th century, **Denis Diderot and Jean le Rond d’Alembert** compiled their *Encyclopédie*, consisting of texts and images intended to describe all of the Western world’s available knowledge. [3] Ironically, the project only demonstrates how the topic at hand is in fact too broad to ever be concluded. An encyclopaedic or lexical approach is thus only suitable for shorter research with a highly specific topic (for example, “fictional user interface designs in early sci-fi series” instead of “science fiction”).

► See also: *Forms of Knowing*, p. 86, and *Non-Knowing*, p. 88



Findings

Foreignness

BE A STRANGER

Artists and designers immerse themselves in a wide variety of (academic) disciplines which they have not mastered in any conventional sense. Where some might consider such a lack of knowledge problematic, artists see here an opportunity – to approach a topic with a completely different mindset than someone who has been deeply involved in it over a longer period of time.

In the early 20th century, filmmaker **Jan Cornelis Mol** developed his own techniques for making films, which allowed him to produce utterly original visuals – and even a kind of colour film, in a time when everything was still in black and white. The image on the left is part of a visual exploration of growing crystals, titled ***From the Crystal Kingdom***. This work can be understood as both scientific documentary and avant-garde cinema – but also as an excellent example of someone entering a territory as an outsider, allowing him to come up with startling new perspectives by thinking “with” or “through” his tools and materials; approaching them intuitively, unconstrained by the seemingly self-evident attitudes and preferences of scientists or traditional practitioners.

When immersing yourself in a subject you don’t know so well, always remember to stay humble. There’s nothing worse than a creative project topped off with a superficial sauce of “scientificness”. The aim of this dabbling in other people’s disciplines is not to come up with the next great work of optics, anthropology or philosophy. Rather, always remain connected to your own background, and you will soon be able to see the relevance of your own perspective. [▶] You should be every bit as clear about what you don’t know, as you are about what you do know. Embracing a quality of not-knowing [▶] can help make space for creative development. Recognise your lack of knowledge, while always continuing to find opportunities to increase your knowledge. It’s precisely this foreignness that will allow you to discover a completely new perspective on a topic that others may have spent years or decades studying.

▶ See: *Academia*, p. 76

▶ See the next two spreads